Foster + Partners designs "highly functional" bird feeders to reduce disease transmission

UK studio Foster + Partners Industrial Design has revealed a bird feeder called Ori at Milan design week that is designed to reduce the spread of disease. The advanced-prototype bird feeders, which were unveiled today, were initiated by the studio's founder Norman Foster and are set to go into production for Italian brand Danese Milano. Ori is designed to be easily dismantled for cleaning to reduce disease transmission, which can occur when birds drop half-eaten food. Foster + Partners Industrial Design has unveiled a bird feeder at Milan design week"Norman instigated the project so we started looking at the design of birdhouses and bird feeders," Foster + Partners Industrial Design lead Mike Holland told Dezeen "We started to glean quite a lot of information on bird feeders and actually found that many official bodies are identifying bird feeders as one of the key disease spreaders," Holland continued. "It is really important to be able to thoroughly clean a bird feeder regularly, so we hit on this idea of a flat pack assembly of components that can easily be disassembled for transport, but also for cleaning." The feeder was designed to reduce disease transmissionThe core of the feeder is a pair of spun aluminium cones, between which the feed is held. Threaded aluminium tubes connected to this core can be configured to create hanging and floor-standing feeders or to make a standing water bath. Foster + Partners Industrial Design also created a series of swappable feeding tubes and cages so that the feeder can be changed at different times of the year or for different species. "We started to realise different types of birds need different types of feeds at different times of year, so we got into the whole idea of having different sleeves – different dispensers," explained Holland. "We're looking at the whole idea of how a bird feeder can change and evolve through the seasons, how it can be cleaned, and at the same time, why can't it be interesting and graphically, a piece of sculpture that you're happy to have within your environment." It was constructed to ensure ease of dismantlingAccording to the team, the appearance of the contemporary feeder was derived both from traditional feeder forms and from functional requirements. "We never sought to design an esthetic – it just kind of evolved through requirements," said Holland. "We weren't trying to create a styled piece, we were just trying to design something that was highly functional and through that function, we hoped that a graphic, sculptural quality would ensue." Norman Foster initiated the project. Sketch by Norman FosterThe colour of the feeders was also functional, with the studio initially choosing dark blue as it was a colour that was appealing to birds. Future releases in dark green and red are also planned. "We did a lot of colour analysis, looking at the colours that birds find appealing or not appealing, and actually white is the colour that they really dislike," said Holland. "So we have been developing a series of three really dark colours – there's going to be a dark blood oxide, sort of red, a very dark green and then this blue." Ahead of Milan design week Foster + Partners Industrial Design rebranded with a Pentagram-designed graphic identity and dedicated website. We also took a look at 10 products that showed the diversity of the work created by the studio. The photography is by Aaron Hargreaves. See our Milan design week 2025 guide on Dezeen Events Guide for information about the many other exhibitions, installations and talks taking place throughout the week.









